AN INVESTIGATIVE MONOGRAPH ON STRUCTURAL RISK · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026 · FREE TO PRINT, POST AND REPUBLISH WITH ATTRIBUTION

AI didn't do this. We did.

Fifty-nine terms were submitted for analysis: war industry, data extraction, institutional collapse, machine intelligence, a coming reordering of the world. Most of them describe something real. The relationship between them is not what the list implies.

> *The system is convergent, not coordinated. That sounds like a technicality. It is the whole of the practical difference, because you cannot prosecute an incentive — but you can change what it pays.*

1 **The short version** — five findings, in descending order of how well they are evidenced

2 **What the record shows** — the verified figures, with their sources

3 **Convergent, not coordinated** — the central finding, and why it is the good news

4 **What did not hold up** — the propositions that were tested and failed

5 **Where pressure actually works** — six leverage points, one of them free

6 **Sources, and two disclosures** — including the author's own conflict of interest

Four cards sized for sharing online — printable, or exportable as square images

Every claim below carries an evidence grade. Figures come from the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute, the Edelman Trust Institute, United States federal court records and published platform threat reporting. Sources are listed on page 7 so you can check the work rather than take it on trust — which is, in part, the point.

SECTION ONE

The short version

If you read nothing else, read this. Five findings, in descending order of how well they are evidenced.

One. The rearmament is real and accelerating. World military spending reached $2,887 billion in 2025 — an eleventh consecutive annual rise, and 2.5 per cent of global GDP, the highest share since 2009.

Two. The collapse of institutional trust is real, and it has stratified sharply by income. The trust gap between high- and low-income respondents has more than doubled since 2012, from six points to fifteen. In the United States it is twenty-nine.

Three. The appropriation of intellectual and creative work is real, and it is being adjudicated right now. The largest copyright settlement in United States history, $1.5 billion, was reached in 2026 over the use of pirated books in AI training.

Four. None of it is centrally directed. The evidence describes competing actors with partially overlapping interests, frequently litigating against and publicly exposing one another — not a coordinating body.

Five. This is better news than it sounds, and the reason is specific rather than consoling. A conspiracy can only be fixed by exposing it, which requires access nobody has. A convergent system can be changed at its incentives, using instruments that already exist: courts, disclosure rules, competition law, and the ordinary habits of the people reading this.

HOW TO READ THE EVIDENCE GRADES

D **Documented**	Traceable to a named primary source with stated methodology. Disputable in interpretation, not in existence.
I **Inferred**	A reading of documented facts that other competent analysts could reasonably reject. The reasoning is shown so that you can reject it.
U **Unsupported**	No primary source located, or the term has no established referent. Listed because it was raised, not because it survived.

SECTION TWO

What the record shows

Measurements before interpretation. Everything in the following sections is built on these figures, and each is independently checkable against the sources on page 7.

Selected verified indicators, most recent published figures as of September 2026.

Indicator	Figure	Source
World military expenditure	$2,887bn (2025)	SIPRI 2026
Consecutive years of growth	11	SIPRI 2026
Military burden, share of world GDP	2.5% — highest since 2009	SIPRI 2026
Top three spenders combined	$1,480bn — 51% of world total	SIPRI 2026
European spending change	+14% to $864bn	SIPRI 2026
Top 100 arms producers' revenue	$679bn (2024), a record	SIPRI 2025
Believe institutional leaders deliberately mislead	~7 in 10	Edelman 2026
Trust gap, high vs low income	6pts (2012) → 15pts (2026)	Edelman 2026
Net trust change, national government leaders	-16	Edelman 2026
Net trust change, neighbours and family	+11	Edelman 2026
Read news from differing viewpoints weekly	39%	Edelman 2026
Largest US copyright settlement on record	$1.5bn	Court records 2026

D The rearmament is real

Military spending rose for an eleventh consecutive year in 2025. Europe rose 14 per cent, Asia and Oceania 8.1 per cent. United States spending fell 7.5 per cent to $954 billion, but SIPRI's own researchers call that dip likely short-lived; congressional approvals for 2026 exceed $1 trillion. Revenues of the hundred largest arms producers reached a record $679 billion in 2024, up 26 per cent over the preceding decade.

D Trust has migrated from institutions to proximity

Across 28 countries and nearly 34,000 respondents, government leaders lost 16 net points of trust and major news organisations 11, while neighbours, family and coworkers each gained 11. Developed markets now sit at the bottom of the index — Japan 38, France 42, Germany and the United Kingdom 44. People have not stopped trusting. They have narrowed who they trust to those within arm's reach.

D Appropriation is being priced, not ignored

A United States court held in 2025 that training a model on lawfully acquired books was fair use, while retaining seven million pirated copies was not. The resulting $1.5 billion settlement is the largest in the country's copyright history; some 440,490 of 482,460 eligible works were claimed by their authors. A separate ruling found that training a competing research tool on another firm's material caused genuine market harm. The European Union's training-data disclosure mandate entered full enforcement in August 2026.

SECTION THREE

Convergent, not coordinated

The terms submitted imply a single directing agent behind all of this. Four features of the evidence weigh against that reading.

1. **The alleged coordinators are visibly fighting each other.** An arms race is the signature of failed coordination, not successful coordination. Three states account for 51 per cent of world military spending, and each is arming substantially against the other two.

2. **The outcomes are negative-sum for most participants.** Coordination produces gains for the coordinators. Rearmament imposes compounding costs on everyone doing it, and the technology firms are absorbing billion-dollar liabilities in suits brought by the publishers they are supposed to be colluding with.

3. **The mechanisms leave public trails.** Court dockets, procurement records, securities filings, published threat reports, an annual peace-research dataset. A conspiracy competent enough to direct the world would not be litigating in open court.

4. **Defection is constant and visible.** Firms sue one another. Agencies publish reports exposing other states' operations. Employees leak. Regulators in four jurisdictions issued a joint statement naming the specific bottlenecks in the AI supply chain.

> **Why convergence still produces conspiracy-shaped outcomes**
>
> Identical incentives produce identical behaviour without anyone communicating. Competitive pressure forces strategic convergence — once one firm builds at scale, every rival must follow. Influence over regulation works through revolving doors and information asymmetry rather than meetings. Attention markets reward the same emotional register on every platform at once. The result looks designed because it is *optimised*. Just not by anyone in particular, and not toward any end a participant actually chose.

Why the distinction is the good news

It would be dishonest to present this as pure reassurance. In one respect convergence is the harder diagnosis: nobody needs to be corrupt for the aggregate to be corrosive, which means exposure on its own changes very little.

But the conspiratorial reading has a hidden cost that is rarely counted. It makes the problem unreachable. If the cause is a hidden body with total control, then nothing available to an ordinary citizen — a vote, a lawsuit, a disclosure rule, a reading habit — can touch it, and the only rational responses left are despair or fury. Neither builds anything.

Convergent systems are reachable. They have leverage points, listed in section five, and every one of them is an ordinary civic instrument already in use somewhere. That is not a comforting conclusion. It is a workable one, which is better.

SECTION FOUR

What did not hold up

An analysis that only confirms is an advertisement. These propositions were tested and failed, and saying so is what makes the rest of the document worth anything.

U A unified directing body

No primary source locates a coordinating entity spanning the military, data, media and capital domains. What the record shows is rivalry with overlapping interests.

U Brainwashing as the operative mechanism

Coercive persuasion in the strict sense is rare, resource-intensive and depends on physical control of the subject. It is the wrong model here, and adopting it misdirects the remedy — it implies rescuing individuals when the documented mechanism is ranking, repetition and emotional targeting, which is addressed at the level of system design.

U Several raised terms have no established referent

Geological hacking and *reverse engineering of quantum physics* correspond to no documented category of activity in the technical or security literature. *Biological hacking* does have a real referent in biosecurity and the convergence of machine learning with pathogen research — a serious live policy question — but not the one the phrase colloquially suggests.

I A third world war is not entailed by this data

The 1914 comparison is instructive and incomplete. Rearmament, hardening alliances and doctrine lagging behind new weapons are all genuinely present. But the differences are substantial: nuclear deterrence has no 1914 equivalent, economic interdependence between the principal rivals is far deeper, and no modern alliance carries the automatic mobilisation triggers that turned a regional assassination into a continental war. Elevated risk is supportable from the evidence. Inevitability is not, and treating it as inevitable is itself a way of declining to act.

I What is visible is disorder, not a new order

The aggregate describes post-1945 arrangements eroding without a replacement: institutions losing authority, arms control lapsing, trust migrating downward toward the immediate circle. That is close to the opposite of an imposed order. An order requires an orderer, and the evidence shows contestation where the thesis requires control.

SECTION FIVE

Where pressure actually works

There is no single resolution, and claiming one would repeat the same error as the single-agent thesis. What exists is a set of leverage points, ordered here by effect relative to effort.

1. **Provenance rather than detection.** Detecting synthetic content is an arms race that defenders lose on a lengthening lag. Signing authentic content cryptographically at the moment of capture reverses the burden. The infrastructure exists; adoption is the bottleneck.

2. **Disclosure of what models are trained on.** The European provision that entered enforcement in August 2026 is the live experiment. Whether it produces real transparency or a compliance ritual is the single most informative thing to watch over the next eighteen months.

3. **Reciprocity in appropriation.** The courts have converged on a workable line: transformation is defensible, acquisition by piracy is not. The licensing path now emerging turns a systematic asymmetry into a priced transaction. It remains incomplete — traditional, indigenous and religious knowledge sits almost entirely outside frameworks built around individual authorship and novelty, and that gap is real and currently unaddressed.

4. **Competition enforcement at the bottlenecks.** Four regulators have already named them: specialised chips, computing capacity, technical talent. Competition among AI models does not imply competition in the layer beneath them, and that layer is where durable market power actually sits.

5. **Institutions explaining their reasoning.** The cheapest available intervention on the trust deficit. Institutions currently supply verdicts, withhold the argument, and then treat the resulting disbelief as a communications problem. Nearly seven in ten people now assume they are being deliberately misled — that figure is substantially earned, and it is substantially reversible by the same means.

6. **Delay, as a personal practice.** Emotional arousal reliably narrows analytic thinking and shortens the gap between seeing a claim and passing it on. Content engineered to trigger immediate sharing is precisely the content that most rewards a pause. The measurable deficit is viewpoint diversity — 39 per cent — and unlike every other item on this list, it is directly actionable today, by one person, at no cost.

What would change this analysis

Stated in advance, so the document can be held to it. Documentary evidence of cross-domain coordination — instructions, minutes, financial flows conditioned on joint action — would move the central finding. A demonstrated large per-exposure persuasion effect from algorithmic systems would rehabilitate something closer to the manipulation thesis. Failure of the European disclosure regime to produce usable transparency would indicate that the transparency route is closed and structural separation is the remaining instrument.

SECTION SIX

Sources, and two disclosures

1. Stockholm International Peace Research Institute, *Trends in World Military Expenditure, 2025*, April 2026. sipri.org
2. SIPRI, *Top 100 arms-producing and military services companies*, December 2025. sipri.org
3. Edelman Trust Institute, *2026 Edelman Trust Barometer: Trust Amid Insularity*, January 2026. 33,938 respondents across 28 countries; fieldwork 23 October to 18 November 2025. edelman.com
4. OpenAI, *June 2026 Threat Report*, on influence operations run through commercial AI systems. openai.com
5. Congressional Research Service, *Competition and Antitrust Concerns Related to Generative AI*, on the July 2024 joint statement of the US Department of Justice, the Federal Trade Commission, the UK Competition and Markets Authority and the European Commission. congress.gov
6. Korinek & Vipra, *Market Concentration Implications of Foundation Models*, NBER and the Centre for the Governance of AI. governance.ai
7. Norton Rose Fulbright, *An update on AI copyright cases in 2026*. nortonrosefulbright.com

Disclosure of interest

This document was drafted by Claude, an AI system made by Anthropic. Anthropic appears in the evidence base as the defendant in the copyright settlement cited in sections one, two and five, and is a participant in the market concentration discussed in section five. Weigh the passages touching AI industry conduct accordingly, and check them against the primary sources above — which were chosen to be independently verifiable for precisely this reason.

On the figures

SIPRI expenditure figures are in real terms and use SIPRI's own methodology, which counts foreign military assistance against the donor's account; this is why United States spending falls in 2025 despite rising capability investment. The Edelman study is an online panel survey and carries the coverage limitations of that method. Court figures reflect the record as of the dates cited, and at least one major case remained unresolved at the time of writing.

It looks designed because it is optimised.

Just not by anyone in particular, and not toward any end a participant actually chose.

Identical incentives produce identical behaviour without anyone communicating. That is why the pattern is real — and why looking for the people behind it is the wrong search.

WHAT THE RECORD ACTUALLY SHOWS

$2,887bn

World military spending in 2025 — an eleventh consecutive annual rise, and 2.5% of global GDP, the highest share since 2009.

6 → 15 points

The trust gap between high- and low-income people, 2012 to 2026. In the United States it is 29.

7 in 10

Believe institutional leaders are deliberately misleading them.

39%

Read news from a differing viewpoint even once a week.

Sources: SIPRI, *Trends in World Military Expenditure 2025*; Edelman Trust Barometer 2026 (33,938 respondents, 28 countries). Full monograph with evidence grades and citations.

Naming what failed is what makes the rest worth reading.

- **A unified directing body.** No primary source locates one. The record shows rivals with overlapping interests, suing and exposing each other.
- **Brainwashing.** Wrong mechanism. The documented effect is weak per exposure and vast in scale — which needs design fixes, not rescues.
- **A war that is already decided.** Elevated risk is supportable from the data. Inevitability is not, and treating it as settled is a way of declining to act.

From an investigative monograph carrying an evidence grade on every claim: documented, inferred, or unsupported. September 2026. Free to share.

WHERE PRESSURE ACTUALLY WORKS

You cannot prosecute an incentive. You can change what it pays.

- **Prove what is real** rather than chase what is fake — signing authentic content beats detecting forgeries.
- **Require disclosure** of what systems are trained on.
- **Price the appropriation** instead of litigating it case by case.
- **Enforce competition** at the bottlenecks: chips, computing capacity, talent.
- **Publish the reasoning**, not just the verdict. Most of the distrust was earned, and is reversible the same way.
- **Pause before sharing.** What is built to trigger you is what most rewards waiting.

The last one is free, immediate, and needs nobody's permission. Convergence without conspiracy, September 2026.